CSE2525 · DATA MINING · 2026–27

Distances & Similarity

Choosing a distance is choosing which patterns an algorithm can see — worked through two case studies.

A. Anand · study deck

PART I

Why distance underlies data mining

Before any formula: what does a distance actually let us do?

THE ONE IDEA TO HOLD ONTO

Choosing a distance is choosing what counts as similar

THE WHOLE LECTURE IN ONE LINE

Every task today — classify, cluster, flag outliers, search — reduces to one question: what is close to what? You answer it by picking a representation and a distance.

Change that choice and the answer changes — *even though not a single data point moved.*

Hold onto this: rank shoes by price and a €120 running shoe's nearest neighbour is a €120 dress shoe; rank by what it's for and its neighbour is another running shoe. Same shop, same data — the distance decided the recommendation.

DISTANCE IS A SHARED BUILDING BLOCK

One dataset — four questions



Mining task	The question, expressed through distance
Classification	Which labelled examples are closest to this new object?
Clustering	Which objects are close enough to form groups?
Anomaly detection	Which objects are far from the usual observations?
Similarity search	Which existing objects are closest to this query?

THE CHOICE, MADE CONCRETE

“Similar” has no default meaning



- Similar in price? — a running shoe lands next to a dress shoe.
- Similar in purpose? — it lands next to other running shoes.
- Similar in description text? — grouped by words, not by use.
- Similar in who buys it? — you get *complements*, not substitutes.

Same two candidates, same query — the nearest neighbour flips with the distance. The task decides which sense you want; the distance is how you encode it.

YOUR TURN · 2 MIN WITH YOUR NEIGHBOUR

Design decision: the “more like this” button

SCENARIO

A music app wants a “more like this” button on every song. You decide what powers it.

— Which of today’s four questions is this — classification, clustering, anomaly, or similarity search?

— What should “similar” mean here — same genre, same tempo & mood, or the same listeners?

— Each answer is a different representation. Which one can you actually compute from the data you have?

There’s no correct answer — only a design decision you can defend. We’ll compare a few.

PART II

Task → representation → distance

The choice of distance is the model — so make the choice deliberately.

“SIMILAR” IS AMBIGUOUS ON PURPOSE

Close in what sense?

— Two shoes can be close in price but different in purpose.

— Two products can have similar descriptions but very different prices.

— Two visually similar products may be substitutes; two bought-together products may be complements.

CONSEQUENCE

Different features give different neighbours. Picking the feature and the distance *is* picking the model — this is the most important idea in the lecture, so we put it first.

FOUR DECISIONS, IN ORDER

Task → representation → distance → decision

Choice	What it determines
Task	What “similar” should mean
Representation	What information is available for comparison
Distance	Which differences matter, and how much
Decision rule	What we do with the resulting distances (e.g. top-k)

And you don’t always need a vector first — trees, strings and sets have distances directly.

YOUR TURN · WALK THE SEQUENCE

Design decision: spot duplicate news articles

SCENARIO

A news aggregator scrapes the same story from dozens of sites, each with small edits. You must group the duplicates — fill in the four decisions.

Decision	Your call for this task
Task	What should “similar” mean — near-identical wording?
Representation	The whole string? a bag of words? a set of word *k*-grams?
Distance	Edit distance? Jaccard on the sets? cosine on term vectors?
Decision rule	Group two articles when the distance is below which threshold?

Notice the dependency: the representation you pick decides which distances are even available to you.

PART III

Metrics as useful guarantees

What properties make a distance predictable — and fast?

DEFINITION

When is a distance a *metric*?

METRIC SPACE

A function $d : X \times X \to \mathbb{R}$ is a **metric** on a set X if, for every $x, y, z \in X$, it satisfies the four axioms below. The pair **(X, d)** is then called a **metric space**.

Axiom	Formal statement
Non-negativity	$d(x, y) \geq 0$
Identity of indiscernibles	$d(x, y) = 0 \iff x = y$
Symmetry	$d(x, y) = d(y, x)$
Triangle inequality	$d(x, z) \leq d(x, y) + d(y, z)$

WHY THESE AXIOMS ARE WORTH DEMANDING

The axioms are guarantees an algorithm can exploit

— Identity and symmetry make “the nearest object” well-defined and independent of comparison order.

— The triangle inequality lets known distances bound unknown ones, so candidates can be ruled out *without* measuring them.

PRUNING WITH THE TRIANGLE INEQUALITY

Suppose a query q is at distance 10 from a reference r, and a candidate c is at distance 2 from r. By the triangle inequality, `d(q, c) ≥ |10 − 2| = 8`. If we only seek neighbours within distance 3, we may discard c **without ever computing d(q, c)**.

This is what powers metric indexes — ball trees, VP-trees — that avoid the full $O(n^2)$ comparisons.

EXERCISE · CHECK THE AXIOMS

Is the Hamming distance a metric?

CANDIDATE DISTANCE

For two strings x, y of equal length n over a fixed alphabet, let $d_H(x, y)$ be the number of positions at which they differ. e.g. $d_H(10110, 11100) = 2$.

— Verify each of the four axioms for d_H.

— Three are immediate; the triangle inequality is the one that takes an argument — reason position by position.

Decide before the next slide: is it a metric, and *why* does the triangle inequality hold?

SOLUTION

Yes — the Hamming distance is a metric

PROOF — VERIFY EACH AXIOM

Non-negativity. d_H is a count of positions, hence $d_H(x, y) \geq 0$.

Identity. $d_H(x, y) = 0 \iff$ no position differs $\iff x = y$.

Symmetry. "position i differs" is the same statement for (x, y) and (y, x), so $d_H(x, y) = d_H(y, x)$.

Triangle inequality. Fix a position i. If $x_i \neq z_i$, then x_i and z_i cannot both equal y_i, so $x_i \neq y_i$ *or* $y_i \neq z_i$. Hence at each position $[x_i \neq z_i] \leq [x_i \neq y_i] + [y_i \neq z_i]$. Summing over all n positions gives $d_H(x, z) \leq d_H(x, y) + d_H(y, z)$.

∎

EXERCISE · FIND THE BROKEN AXIOM

Is squared Euclidean distance a metric?

CANDIDATE DISTANCE

On $\mathbb{R}^n$, define $d_{sq}(x, y) = \|x - y\|^2 = \sum_i (x_i - y_i)^2$ — the **squared** Euclidean distance (the quantity k-means minimises).

— Three of the four axioms clearly hold. Which one can fail?

— Try to build a counterexample using three points on the real line.

Hint: place three points in a row and compare the direct jump against the two-step path.

SOLUTION

No — the triangle inequality fails

COUNTEREXAMPLE ON THE REAL LINE

Take $x = 0$, $y = 1$, $z = 2$. Then

$d_{sq}(x, z) = (2 - 0)^2 = \mathbf{4}$, while $d_{sq}(x, y) + d_{sq}(y, z) = 1^2 + 1^2 = \mathbf{2}$.

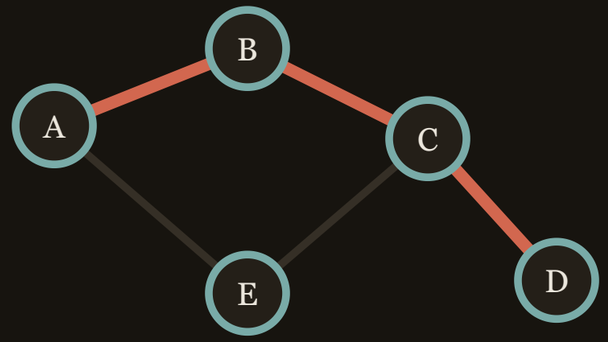
So $d_{sq}(x, z) = 4 > 2 = d_{sq}(x, y) + d_{sq}(y, z)$ — the triangle inequality is violated.

TAKEAWAY

Non-negativity, identity and symmetry all hold, yet d_{sq} is not a metric. Squaring breaks the triangle inequality — which is exactly why the Euclidean distance (its square root) is used wherever metric structure is required.

A METRIC ON OBJECTS THAT ARE NOT VECTORS

Worked example: shortest-path distance on a graph



DEFINITION

In a connected graph, `d(u, v)` is the number of edges on a **shortest path** between u and v (the **geodesic** distance; for weighted graphs, the smallest total edge weight).

— BFS from A reads the distance straight off the layer number:

— `layer 0 = {A},  1 = {B, E},  2 = {C},  3 = {D}`.

— So `d(A,D) = 3`, along A–B–C–D *or* A–E–C–D.

— Triangle check: `d(A,D) = 3 ≤ d(A,C) + d(C,D) = 2 + 1`. ✓

It is a metric: any path through a third node w is itself a valid $u \to v$ path, so the shortest cannot be longer — the triangle inequality holds by construction.

KEEP THESE SEPARATE

Valid metric ≠ useful distance

ASK BOTH, INDEPENDENTLY

1 · Is it a mathematically valid metric? 2 · Does it capture the similarity our task needs?

Neither answer settles the other. A valid metric can be useless for a task; a genuinely useful dissimilarity need not satisfy every axiom. We'll see both in the case studies.

YOUR TURN · DO YOU NEED A METRIC?

Design decision: 10 million face photos

SCENARIO

You must find near-duplicate faces in a 10-million-photo archive — far too many to compare every pair.

— To prune candidates without computing every distance, which axiom must your distance obey — and why that one?

— Your score gives $d(A,B) \neq d(B,A)$. Which axiom breaks, and does it actually matter here?

— Keep the two questions apart: is your score a valid metric, and does it capture “same person”?

The point of this part: metric properties aren’t pedantry — the triangle inequality is what makes the search feasible at all.

PART IV · CASE STUDY 1

Products: which differences matter

Designing a similarity, as a sequence of decisions.

“I WANT TO SUGGEST SIMILAR ITEMS”

First decide what relevance means



What makes a product a useful recommendation for another — shared category? co-purchase? “related items” / clicks vs. purchases define the target before any distance is chosen.

WHAT INFORMATION IS AVAILABLE

Four representations of a product

Category

- Where it sits in the catalogue tree

Text

- Title & description terms

Price

- A single numeric feature

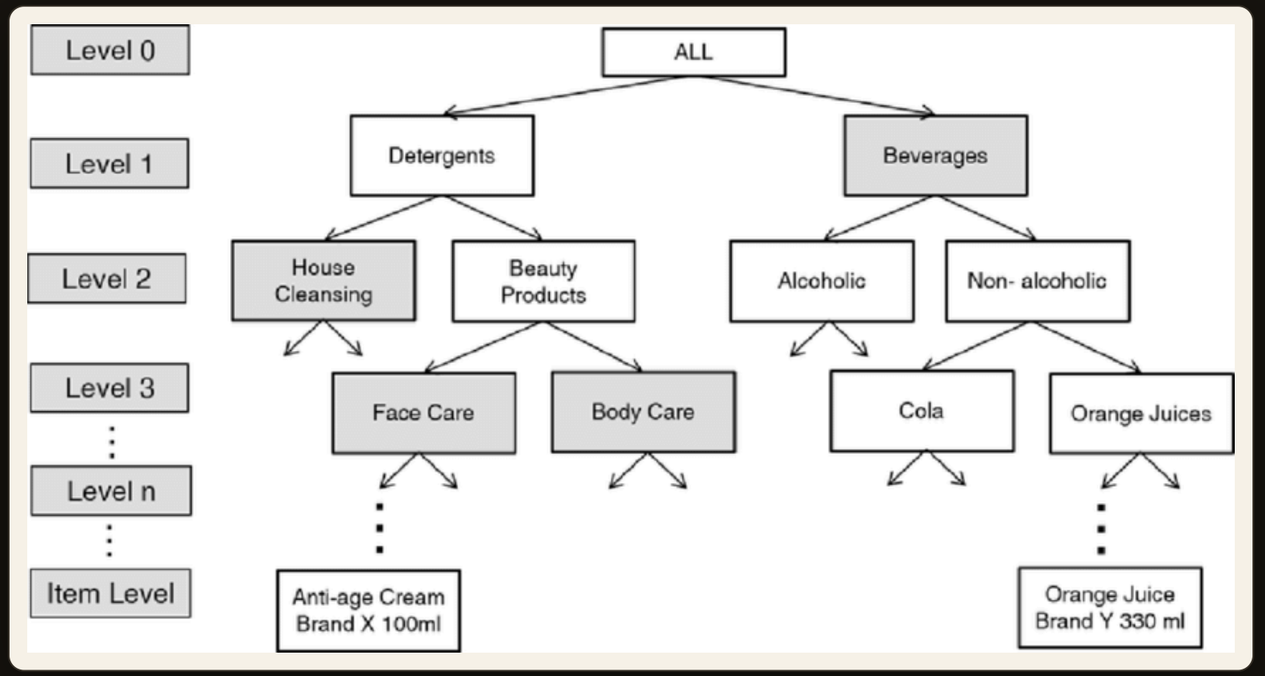
Reviews

- Ratings & their distribution

Each representation needs its own distance — and each will disagree about who the neighbours are.

CATEGORY → A TREE

Taxonomy distance = shortest path



Distance = path length up to a common ancestor and back down. A tree is a graph, so this is exactly the shortest-path distance from Part III — and it is a metric on category nodes. But distinct products in the same category have distance 0, so the representation, not the metric, is the limit.

TEXT → DIRECTION OF A TERM VECTOR

Cosine: similar wording, any length

$$\cos(\theta) = (a \cdot b) / (\|a\| \, \|b\|) \quad d_{cos} = 1 - \cos(\theta)$$

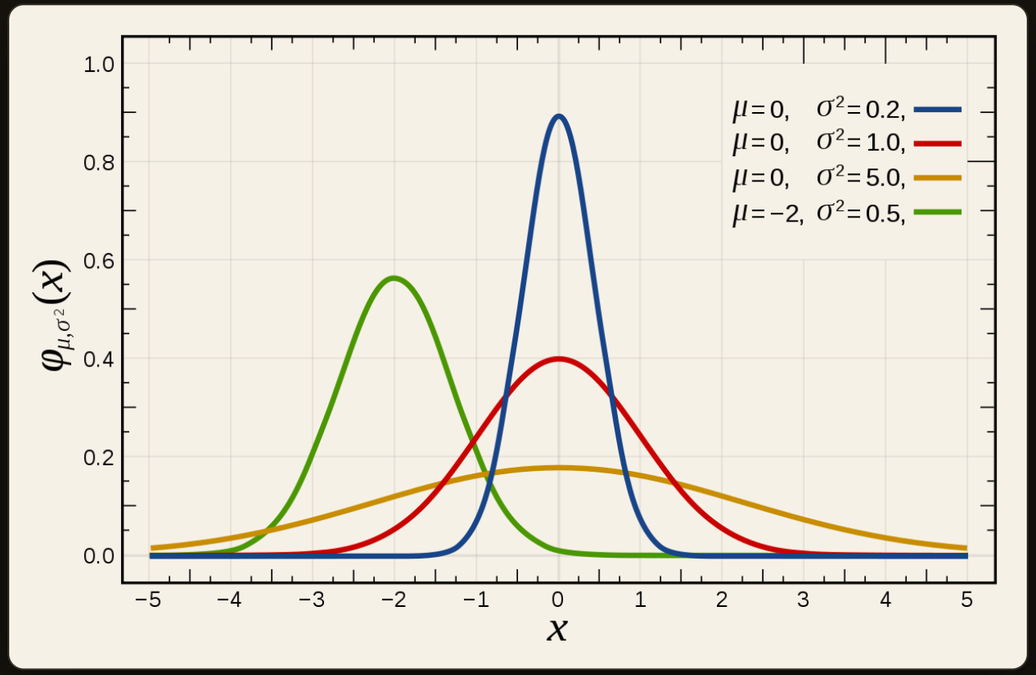
READ IT CAREFULLY

Only the direction of the term vectors matters, never their length — great for descriptions of different sizes.

Mind two traps: distance 0 means same direction, not identical (proportional vectors collapse to 0); and $1 - \cos\theta$ is not a true metric — it can violate the triangle inequality. Useful, but not a metric.

PRICE → EUCLIDEAN, BUT BEWARE UNITS

Standardize — then don’t over-trust it



Raw price dominates small-scale features, so standardize: z = (x − μ)/σ. But equal scale ≠ equal relevance, and it does not remove outlier sensitivity — scaling is not a priority decision.

REVIEWS → SPARSE & COLD-START

What about products with no history?



Most products have few reviews; brand-new ones have none (cold start). The distance must degrade gracefully when a representation is missing or thin.

QUESTION

Your query is a **running shoe**. Ranked by **price**, the single closest product is a formal **dress shoe**. Is that a good recommendation — and what decides the answer?

Same three candidates, three different distances.

Think — then → for the answer.

SEE THE CHOICE CHANGE THE ANSWER

One query, three candidates, three rankings

QUERY

a **running shoe** · €120 · *Footwear › Running* · “lightweight breathable running shoe”.

Candidate	By price	By category	By text
A · trail running shoe (€130)	near (Δ10)	nearest — same “Running”	near — “running shoe”
B · running socks (€15)	far (Δ105)	far — Apparel › Socks	near — “breathable lightweight running”
C · formal dress shoe (€125)	nearest (Δ5)	mid — shares “Footwear”	far — only “shoe”

Price crowns a dress shoe; text pulls in socks; only the right representation ranks the other running shoe first. The distance is the model.

FROM OBJECTIVE TO ALGORITHM

Combine distances — weights are priorities

$$d(x,y) = w_c \cdot d_{category} + w_t \cdot d_{text} + w_p \cdot d_{price}$$

TWO CAUTIONS, LINKED

The terms must be on comparable scales before you add them — exactly the standardization point again.

The weights w encode priorities; they are the model's hyperparameters. Standardization does not choose them for you — you decide what should matter. Then rank the top-k neighbours and evaluate against real clicks/purchases.

PART V · CASE STUDY 2

Videos: which differences to ignore

Invariance, thresholds, and a system that scales.

YOUTUBE: NEAR-DUPLICATES OF AN UPLOAD

Equivalent for our task, different in the bytes



Figure 1. Examples of queries and near-duplicate videos from CC_WEB_VIDEO dataset.

What should be ignored: re-encoding, modest colour changes, logos/overlays, small crops. The job is the opposite of case 1 — choosing differences to discard.

BYTE EQUALITY IS THE WRONG TOOL

Exact ≠ near

THE FAILURE

Byte equality and **cryptographic hashes** (MD5, SHA) are designed so one changed pixel flips the whole digest. They detect **identical files**, never **perceptually similar** ones.

We need a representation where small perceptual changes → small distance.

CONSTRUCT THE RIGHT REPRESENTATION

Perceptual hashing (pHash)

THE GENERAL IDEA

Reduce each frame to a short fingerprint that survives re-encoding and minor edits — typically from low-frequency structure, so cosmetic changes don’t move it.

Keep the idea separate from any one scheme. Code length, keyed behaviour and non-invertibility are properties of *particular* hashes, not defining features of perceptual hashing in general.

COMPARE → HAMMING DISTANCE

Count the differing bits

$a = 10110010 \quad b = 10111010 \rightarrow d_{Hamming} = 1$

BACK TO PART III

Hamming distance is a proper metric on fingerprints — we verified all four axioms in Part III.

Yet distinct videos can share a fingerprint. A metric *in the representation space* does not guarantee the originals are distinguishable — the same lesson as taxonomy-distance on products.

MAKE A DECISION, ACCEPT ERRORS

Pick a threshold — trade off the two mistakes

DECISION RULE

call it a near-duplicate when Hamming distance ≤ **τ**.

- Threshold too tight → miss real duplicates (false negatives).
- Threshold too loose → flag unrelated videos (false positives).
- τ is chosen from data — exactly the kind of knob the task, not the metric, decides.

MAKE IT SCALE

Fast filter → slow check

cheap candidate generation → expensive exact verification

A RECURRING PATTERN — FAST FILTER, SLOW CHECK

Generate a small candidate set cheaply (fingerprint buckets / LSH), then verify the few survivors with the expensive comparison. Never materialise all n^2 distances.

The same shape powers web search, retrieval and question answering — a recurring pattern this year.

SYNTHESIS

Change the distance, change the patterns

Why this one choice ripples through every task.

BACK TO THE FOUR TASKS

Changing the distance changes the answer

- Nearest neighbours change → classifications and recommendations change.
- Neighbourhoods change → clusters and density estimates change.
- What counts as “far” changes → detected anomalies change.

Case	Main lesson
Products	Choosing which differences matter
Videos	Choosing which differences to ignore

TAKE AWAY · AND A TRANSFER EXERCISE

Choosing a distance is choosing what you can see

THE MESSAGE

Task → representation → distance → decision. Metrics buy predictability and speed; but a valid metric and a task-useful distance are two separate questions.

Choosing a distance is choosing which patterns an algorithm can see.

Transfer: for detecting duplicate news articles — what representation would you choose, which changes should be ignored, and how would you evaluate the result?